Topic: The War of Independence

War of independence was the culmination of decades of struggle starting from the language movement began in 1948. Language movement was a precursor to the larger movements for our freedom, for our emancipation against cultural, political and economic control. After the successful uprising of students in 1969, General Ayub Khan, had to hand over power. But instead of handing it to the civilian government, he handed over power to the army chief General Yahya Khan. Martial Law was re imposed, but simultaneously it was agreed that elections would be arranged on the basis of universal adult franchise to establish a democratic government in the country. It was decided in the Legal Framework Order of 1970 that out of 313 National Assembly seats, East Pakistan would get 169 seats because of its population majority. Before the election a devastating cyclone attacked East Pakistan and killed half a million people. The sufferings of the cyclone victims, once again, made East Pakistanis realize that Pakistan government had no sensitivity towards their needs and problems which was very much reflected in the results of 1970 election. Awami League emerged as the single majority party in the Pakistan National Assembly with 160 seats out of 162 seats in East Pakistan whereas Zulfiqar Ali Bhutto's Pakistan People's party won 81 seats (all from the Western Wing), and emerged as the second largest party. And yet Bhutto refused to transfer power to Sheikh Mujibur Rahman and his party. The result was more disquieting for Yahya khan and the military generals who had been in a pre-poll assessment and told that no party could take a clear lead and there would be a coalition government which could be easily handled by West Pakistan. All pre-poll predictions proved wrong and they started conspiring against Sheikh Mujibur Rahman. In fact, in January 17, 1971,Yahya met Bhutto and top military generals at Larkana to draw the plan of genocide on East Pakistan. It was all drawn up at that time but Yahya needed more time to bring the troops in East Pakistan.

The first session of Parliament was supposed to sit in Dhaka on March 3, 1971, but President Yahya in a sudden radio speech had declared the postponement of the National Assembly session for an indefinite period. Upon hearing this news Bengalis erupted in anger and eventually group by group people of all classes took to the streets and spontaneously all stores and business centers in the city closed down as well. The cricket match being held in Dhaka stadium was suspended and audiences left the stadium to take part in protests and to receive further directions from Sheikh Mujibur Rahman. West Pakistan imposed a curfew to try to calm down the protests, but failed and wantonly killed thousands of innocent civilians by military firing. On March 2, 1971, a few courageous youths of Dhaka University led by ASM Rob, the then vice president of Dhaka University Students' Union, raised the flag of Bangladesh, a green background with a red circle symbolizing the rising sun nestled in Bangladesh's map in center. Next day, Bangabandhu addressed a meeting in Paltan Maidan and announced the manifesto of the new independent nation, declared our national anthem and called for the non-cooperation movement. Though the people of East Pakistan expected Bangabandhu to declare independence but being a democrat he tried to find a peaceful solution. On March 7, Sheikh Mujib attended by over a million people where he said, 'the struggle this time is for emancipation, the struggle this time is for independence'. While Bangabandhu was speaking, armed forces under the command of Khadim

Hossain Raja were waiting to fire on the unarmed civilians the minute the proclamation of independence was uttered.

Finally as the sequel to 'Operation Blitz', 'Operation Search Light 'was carried out by the Pakistani army. Just before being arrested Sheikh Mujib declared independence of Bangladesh through the police wireless and that was then sent to Chittagong where the general secretary of Awami League broadcast independence from Chittagong radio. Later, Ziaur Rahman as a major of the 8th EPR of Chittagong also gave a declaration on behalf of Bangabandhu on the 27th March, 1971, as a representative of Bengali military forces which had a strong impact over the civilians. However, the military forces continued killing under operational search light and the targeted areas were student halls, university teachers, HQ of Police and East Pakistan Rifles, Hindu residential areas and urban slums. An exile government was formed on 10th April with Sheikh Mujibur Rahman as president, Syed Nazrul Islam as Vice President, Tajuddin Ahmed as Prime Minister and MAG Osmani as Commander of Mukti Bahini. The government took oath on 17th April at Mujibnagar, Meherpur,Kushtia which was still an independent area.

Mukti Bahini consisted of the regular and irregular forces. The regulars included East Bengal regiment, East Pakistan rifles, police etc. On the other hand, the young fighters with limited training became irregular forces. The country was divided into 11 sectors each with a sector commander. Later on, aside from the regular forces, three brigade forces i.e. S, K and Z force were created and named after the initial letter of the name of the commander. Naval and air wings were also created during the war time. Another noteworthy force was Kader Bahini under the leadership of kader Siddiqui from Tangail who built up a massive force and was one of the 1st to enter Dhaka from the North along with Indian Army. However, the most decorated platoon was Crack Platoon in entire Mukti Bahini as they were involved in commando operations in Dhaka, center of the country and its surroundings.

The general people of the country supported the freedom fighters wholeheartedly which proved that it was a People's war. In the meantime 10 million Bangladeshis fled to India as refugees and India stood solidly behind Bangladesh throughout the war period. Shadhin Bangla Betar Kendro inspired the people through different activities to keep their morale high. The military-bureaucratic alliance of West Pakistan continued killing the intellectuals of Bangladesh over the nine months but this took a serious turn on 14 December when over 200 of intellectuals where abducted from their homes in Dhaka and brutally killed with the help of Jamaat-e-Islami and others. To conclude, this genocide and all the blood that went provide us with the freedom that now we enjoy. We should remember this glorious chapter of our history and work to achieve the aspirations of our freedom fighters.

Suggested readings:

Maniruzzaman, Talukder, The Bangladesh Revolution and Its Aftermath (Dhaka: The University Press Limited, 1988), Chapter 6, pp. 108-140.

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Khasru, B.Z, Myths and Facts: Bangladesh Liberation War: How India, U.S., China, and the U.S.S.R. Shaped the Outcome (India: Rupa Publications, 2010).

Mohsin, K.M. and Islam, Rafiqul, "War of Liberation: Civil and Military Resistance", in Sirajul Islam (ed.), History of Bangladesh, 1704-1971 (Volume I: Political History), (Dhaka: Asiatic Society of Bangladesh, 2nd edition, 2000), pp. 612-662.

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